# The Language of AI

Talk about AI honestly, talk to it clearly, and know where to draw the line.

## 1 · TALKING ABOUT AI: THE 4-SENTENCE BRIEF

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **WHAT IT DOES** | This **[tool]** takes **[input]** and gives **[output]**, so **[who]** can **[spend time on what]**.<br>Name the task it takes off someone's desk, not the technology. |
| 2 | **THE HONEST PROMISE** | It **[does what well]**, but it can **[go wrong how]**, so **[what we do about it]**.<br>Say how often it goes wrong, and what you do about it. |
| 3 | **WHO HOLDS THE WHEEL** | For **[type of task]**, **[named role]** **[checks / decides]** before **[action]**.<br>Name a role, such as "the shift supervisor", not "a human". |
| 4 | **THE ASK** | I need **[decision]** from **[who]** by **[date]**.<br>One decision they can say yes or no to. Not "thoughts?" |

## FOR SENTENCE 2: WHAT YOU CAN HONESTLY PROMISE

| IF IT… | YOU CAN PROMISE |
|---|---|
| **Follows fixed rules** | "It does exactly what we set, every time, and nothing else." |
| **Predicts** | "It gives a likelihood, not a certainty. Here's how often it misses." |
| **Drafts or answers** | "It's fast and usually right (here's how often), but it can be wrong and sound sure. A person checks what matters." |
| **Acts on its own** | "It acts only within limits we set in advance, and a named person reviews what it does." |

## FOR SENTENCE 3: LEVELS OF CONTROL

| LEVEL | USE IT FOR |
|---|---|
| **1 · A person decides** | Safety, big money, people's rights, anything you can't undo |
| **2 · A person checks** | Policy, customers, anything that leaves the team |
| **3 · It runs alone** | Low stakes, easy to spot, easy to undo |

**The test: if it's wrong, who gets hurt, and can we undo it?**

## SAME BRIEF, DIFFERENT ROOM: KEEP ALL FOUR, CHANGE THE ORDER

| ROOM | ORDER | START WITH |
|---|---|---|
| **Executive or sponsor** | **4 → 1 → 2 → 3** | The decision you need |
| **Staff who will use it** | **1 → 3 → 2 → 4** | What changes in their day; sentence 4 is what you need them to do |
| **Risk, legal or regulator** | **3 → 2 → 1 → 4** | Who holds the wheel |

## 2 · TALKING TO AI: THE 5-PART PROMPT

| PART | WHAT IT COVERS | EXAMPLE |
|---|---|---|
| **1 · Role** | Who the AI should act as | *"Act as a communications advisor."* |
| **2 · Task** | What you want done | *"Rewrite this project update as a 4-sentence brief."* |
| **3 · Context** | The background, and who it's for | *"It's for a non-technical director who must approve a pilot."* |
| **4 · Format** | Length, style and structure | *"Plain words, under 100 words."* |
| **5 · Check** | What it should flag for you | *"Then list anything you assumed or aren't sure about."* |

### A PROMPT YOU CAN COPY (NO CONFIDENTIAL DETAILS)

Act as a communications advisor. Rewrite the project below as a 4-sentence brief for a non-technical director: (1) what it does, in plain words; (2) what it does well, how often it goes wrong, and what we do about it; (3) who checks or decides before anything important happens; (4) the one decision I need, from whom, by when. Plain words, under 100 words. Then list anything you assumed or aren't sure about. Project: [2–3 lines, no confidential details]

## BEFORE YOU USE ANYTHING AI WROTE

- **Is every fact true?** It can be wrong and sound sure.
- **Did it add anything you didn't give it?** Numbers, names and promises are the usual suspects.
- **Would you sign your name to it?** If not, it isn't finished.

## 3 · WHERE TO DRAW THE LINE: SEVEN QUESTIONS BEFORE YOU USE OR BUY AN AI TOOL

| | |
|---|---|
| **Fairness** | Does it work equally well for everyone it affects? |
| **Accountability** | Who answers for it when it's wrong? |
| **Transparency** | Do people know AI is involved, and can we explain its answers? |
| **Ethics** | Should we do this at all, even if we can? |
| **Safety** | What's the worst that happens if it fails, and who notices? |
| **Security** | Where does our data go, and who can see it? |
| **Sovereignty** | Where is our data stored and processed, and under whose laws? |

## SECURITY: ATTACKERS USE AI TOO

- Never paste confidential information into an AI tool.
- Use the AI tools your organization has approved.
- Treat urgent messages, links and voice notes with extra suspicion.

## SUSTAINABILITY: USE AI WHERE IT EARNS ITS PLACE

- Use it where it saves real effort.
- Ask once, well, instead of five times.
- Keep your own judgment for what matters most.

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